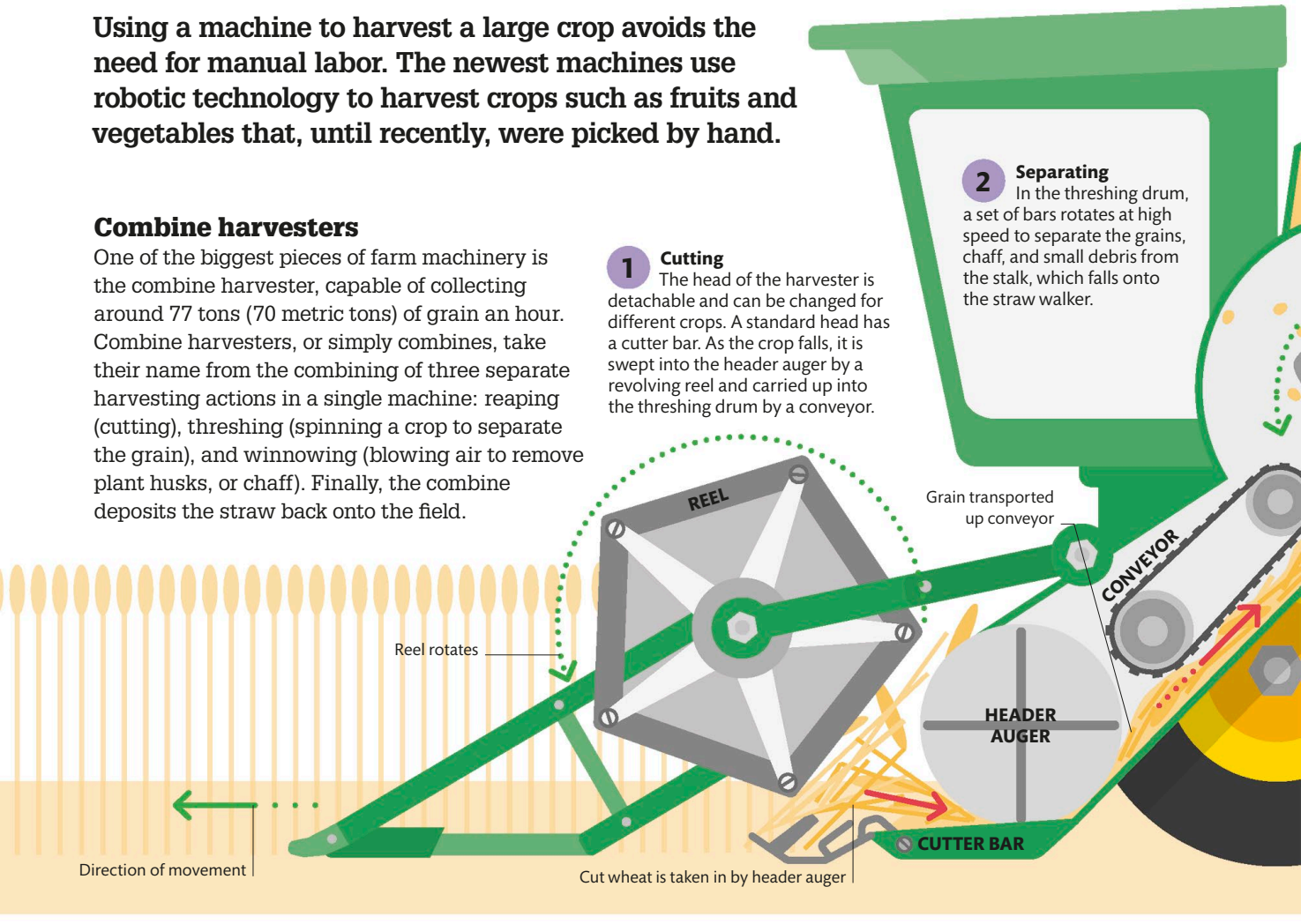
Harvesters

Using a machine to harvest a large crop avoids the need for manual labor. The newest machines use robotic technology to harvest crops such as fruits and vegetables that, until recently, were picked by hand.

Combine harvesters

One of the biggest pieces of farm machinery is the combine harvester, capable of collecting around 77 tons (70 metric tons) of grain an hour. Combine harvesters, or simply combines, take their name from the combining of three separate harvesting actions in a single machine: reaping (cutting), threshing (spinning a crop to separate the grain), and winnowing (blowing air to remove plant husks, or chaff). Finally, the combine deposits the straw back onto the field.



The future of harvesting

Robots could be the future of fruit and vegetable harvesting. Some prototype robot pickers use sensors to assess whether a crop is ready to harvest. Others combine this with a camera that detects the color of the crop. Picking produce requires delicate handling; for fruits such as apples, robot pickers use a vacuum arm to suction the fruit, while other robots use implements to carefully snip the fruit or vegetable off its stem.

